PHASE 0 · COMPETITOR RESEARCH REPORT

LOKOJA LIFE vs LAGOS LIFE

An evidence-backed study of the viral Lagos Life browser game and a screen-by-screen comparison with our own Lokoja Life: verified competitor profile, player sentiment, visual audit, feature matrix, ranked gap analysis and a recommended roadmap. Research only — no code was modified in this phase.

Internal research — Lokoja Life team

Captured and verified 10 October 2026 · Sources in Appendix A

STUDY BEFORE BUILDING

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1. Executive Summary and Method

This report exists because an outside viewer told us, honestly: the project is good, but Lagos Life currently looks better. Rather than argue with that impression, we treated it as a research question. Over one working day we studied the real Lagos Life product from every angle the public internet allows, opened the game itself and played through its entire first-time experience on a phone-sized viewport, audited our own repository screen by screen, and captured equivalent screenshots of both products. This document records what we found, what it means, and what we should do about it. No code in Lokoja Life was modified during this phase, exactly as instructed.

The headline finding is uncomfortable but precise. Lagos Life is not winning because of a superior engine, a bigger world, or deeper simulation; by our own engineering measures our 3D world, movement controller and economy are more ambitious. It is winning because of presentation and aliveness. Its very first screen is the living city itself, crowded with real players, live counters and working billboards. Its onboarding is a four-minute story that ends with the player standing inside their own 3D home with a concrete next action. Its phone is a delightful miniature iOS with a chat layer connected to real people. Every screen radiates the feeling that something is happening right now. Lokoja Life today is a well-engineered, visually coherent single-player world that quietly waits for the player to discover it. That difference, not 3D versus 2D, is what the feedback was measuring.

5,874,313

Total players shown on lagoslife.app/stats, captured 10 Oct 2026 (self-reported, unaudited)

130,287

Players online at the same capture; 1,396,143 active that day; 35.2M visits all time

$10M

Valuation 8 days after launch, from a $500K pre-seed by Vatar Inc (Techpoint Africa, 9 Oct 2026)

Method and evidence discipline

Every factual claim in this report carries a source, and every source was opened and read rather than recalled from memory. We tier the evidence so the reader can weigh it. Tier A is official material: the lagoslife.app landing page, live stats page, Terms of Use, Game and Brand Disclaimer, and the Google Play listing, all captured on 10 October 2026. Tier B is independent press: Vanguard, Techpoint Africa, TechCabal, TechBrief Africa and Technext, published between 6 and 9 October 2026. Tier C is community signal:

TikTok, Instagram, X and Nairaland items discovered through search, plus one creator interview (Fisayo Fosudo, 7 October). Tier D is fan infrastructure: three independent guide sites that had already documented the game's data in remarkable detail. Where numbers are the developer's own - player counts, revenue, tap-through rates - we say so explicitly, because none of them are independently audited.

One disclosure, made deliberately. To answer the question of why players might prefer Lagos Life we needed to see more than its landing page, so we created a single throwaway research account (username lokoresearch01) on 10 October 2026 and walked the full new-player path: sign-up, character creation, the birth lottery, home selection, the welcome tour, the phone, the map, the jobs app and a venue sheet. We confirmed the 18+ gate during sign-up, made no real-money purchases, entered no third-party personal data, and used the account for observation only. All screenshots in this report were captured by us during that session, or of our own game on a local dev server, and are reproduced here solely for internal comparative analysis; all trademarks and assets remain the property of their respective owners, and nothing has been copied into Lokoja Life.

Limitations, stated plainly

- Direct comment threads on Instagram, TikTok and Reddit could not be read without account logins, so player voice is reconstructed from search-indexed snippets, press interviews and guide-site summaries rather than raw threads. We did not invent any quotation, rating or count.
- All Lagos Life scale and revenue figures are self-reported on its own dashboard or in founder interviews. Press counting the same dashboards produced figures from 670,000 (Arise News, early October) to 4.3 million players (TechCabal, 8 October), which shows how soft these numbers are.
- The game is nine days old at the time of writing. Anything observed this week, including prices, features and even the economy itself, may already have changed; the founder ships updates daily.
- Our own product was audited through its code, its test suite (136 checks, all passing) and fresh screenshots at 390 px; we did not run formal user testing on either product.

2. Deliverable 1 - Competitor Profile: Lagos Life

Identity and delivery

Lagos Life is a free, browser-based, multiplayer life simulation set in a shared virtual Lagos, launched on 1 October 2026 - Nigeria's Independence Day. It was created by Shalom Rayhamen, a UK-based Nigerian developer who posts as @Shalom_HeyEliy and operates the game personally per its Terms of Use. Within a week the operation formalised: Vatar, Inc. was incorporated in Delaware on 5 October and closed a $500,000 pre-seed at a $10 million valuation, with participation from Flutterwave CEO Olugbenga Agboola's fund Resilience17, Oo Nwoye, Terra Industries CEO Nathan Nwachuku and Mono CEO Abdulhamid Hassan (Techpoint Africa, 9 October). The Google Play listing, which went live around 8-10 October under developer GreatCallie, packages the same web game as an Android app; the founder has said

native Android and iOS apps could arrive by the end of October. The Play Store entry is verified genuine - its screenshots are pixel-identical to the browser experience we played - and carries a Simulation category label, a 3+ rating with an 18+ age gate enforced in-game, and a 10 October 2026 update date, indicating a daily shipping cadence.

Verified scale (all self-reported)

The game's public stats page, updated every 30 seconds, showed the following when captured on 10 October 2026: 130,287 players online, 1,396,143 active today, 1,539,123 active yesterday, 5,874,313 total players, 4,537,873 visits today and 35,210,661 visits all time. Press reports along the timeline: one million players within three days (Technext, 7 October, described as faster than ChatGPT's launch curve), roughly 2.5 million players and 23 million visits by day four with a peak of 122,000 concurrent users (Technext), and 4.3 million players by 8 October (TechCabal). Arise News counted over 670,000 total players at its own earlier checkpoint, which usefully illustrates that these figures are soft. The honest summary: this is one of the fastest-growing African consumer products ever observed, and the exact numbers matter less than the order of magnitude.

What the product actually is

Lagos Life is a Sims-style persistent world played with other real people. A new player signs up with a username and password (email optional), then builds a Sim through a five-step wizard: look (a rotatable 3D avatar with Nigerian hairstyles including Gele and Braids, outfits from Classic to Owambe, and fabric patterns including Ankara, Adire and Aso-oke); two personality traits chosen from ten that carry real mechanical effects (Hustler grows the Hustle skill faster and bosses notice; Lazy Bone's energy lasts longer but work suffers); one lifetime dream such as Oga at the Top, Lekki Landlord (net worth of one million naira), Afrobeats Star, Everybody's Padi (best friends with four people) or Yaba Unicorn (get a startup funded at CcHub); a birth lottery that assigns once per account either Nepo Baby (500,000 naira pocket money and a Lekki flat) or LAPO Baby (a 60,000 naira loan repaid at 12,000 naira per week); and a first home with explicit trade-offs - a UNILAG hall bunk at 1,200 naira weekly rent, a Mushin face-me-I-face-you room at 2,400, a Yaba self-contain at 6,000, or a locked Lekki mini-flat the game teases with the line: with LAPO money? Work your way here.

From there the loop is: live in your furnished 3D room; keep six needs green (hunger, energy, fun, social, hygiene, bladder) which decay on their own; work shifts through a phone Jobs app listing 32 careers at five levels each (160 positions, from 6,600 to 99,000 naira per shift per the fan wiki's data-driven tables); pay rent every Saturday; move around a city of 31 venues in Lagos with roughly 275 documented activities, plus Abuja with 69 places and 348 activities and Port Harcourt (both added 6 October); and above all, meet other players - chat publicly at venues, DM by username, form groups, visit houses, transfer money, and vote in a weekly governor election whose winner issues decrees with real gameplay effects (a captured notification read: minimum wage raise is now law in Lagos; everyone earns 15 percent more per shift, by Governor @Franka). Six of the eight reviewer-visible systems - jobs, needs, rent, transport with five modes (Trek, Keke, Danfo, Okada, Cab), socialising and city switching - were personally verified in our play session.

The social layer: the phone

The phone is the product's signature. It opens as a loving iPhone recreation on a Lagos-sunset gradient wallpaper, complete with status bar, a large clock reading Friday 9 October - Lagos, and a grid of colourful app icons: Jobs, Messages, Games, Contacts, Help and guide, Courses, Ride, Chowdeck (a real Nigerian delivery brand), Bank, Boutique, Forbes, Houses, Cars, Invite, Health, Invest, Assurance and LagosBet. Alongside the system apps sit third-party entries badged NEW - Meetumo, PopOut Tickets, Eleventhco, Nollywood, Bet Tips, versiah.com - which are paid app placements sold to brands, exactly as the Terms of Use describe under purchasing: virtual application placement on a player's in-game phone. Messages separates Chats from Groups, supports push notifications, and its empty state reads: no chats yet; meet real players around Lagos, or tap a house on the map, and say hi. The social layer is not a menu bolted onto a game; it is the game's reason to return, and the empty state itself pushes the player back into the world.

Economy, monetisation and live operations

The game monetises from day one through five streams (founder statements via Techpoint and TechCabal): advertising - virtual billboards rented to real businesses from about 5,000 naira per week at launch, rising to 50,000, plus sea plots at 18,000 and stats-page slots; music promotion; brand deals; football streaming; and optional wallet top-ups where players buy in-game naira with real money through Flutterwave. One reported campaign produced 3,686 taps from 9,826 app opens - a 38 percent tap-through that TechBrief Africa correctly frames as a single unaudited campaign rather than a benchmark. The economy has visibly strained under growth: the founder admitted there was too much money in the game, a cash-generation loophole spread trillions through player transfers, her fix flagged transfer-only accounts and zeroed some balances, and the team now sells expensive goods to wealthy players - we have created a class, we need to offer that class their value. Players have asked to withdraw real money; the Terms firmly refuse, defining Game Naira as non-redeemable. Live operations are constant: compensation gifts (we received 1,000,000 naira for patience during an outage day), a server-wide daily gem hunt with a next-prize counter, elections, and city launches.

Technology and delivery observations

Publicly observable facts only: the game runs in any modern mobile or desktop browser with no download, and spreads through links on X, WhatsApp, TikTok and Instagram; it supports add-to-home-screen with an in-game install banner calling itself faster to open, like a real app; infrastructure moved from Cloudflare's database to DigitalOcean to AWS with autoscaling within the first week, costing roughly 6,000 dollars per month according to the founder; reliability is imperfect - the fan guide maintains a fixes page for a Reconnecting to Lagos state; and the whole thing was built fast with AI-assisted tooling by a developer who credits The Sims 3 and the danfo driving game Lagos Run as inspirations. None of this is criticism; it is the operating model: build in weeks, ship daily, monetise the attention immediately, and fix in public.

Attribute	Verified finding
Launch	1 October 2026 (Independence Day); browser-only at launch

Attribute	Verified finding
Creator	Shalom Rayhamen (@Shalom_HeyEliy), UK-based Nigerian developer; operator per Terms of Use
Company	Vatar, Inc. (Delaware, 5 Oct 2026); $500K pre-seed at $10M valuation (Techpoint, 9 Oct)
Android app	Play Store listing by GreatCallie live by 10 Oct 2026; wrapper of the web game
Age gate	18+ enforced at sign-up; Terms permit closure of underage accounts
Cities	Lagos plus Abuja and Port Harcourt (both added 6 Oct 2026)
Venues	31 places in Lagos, 69 in Abuja (fan-wiki counts); airport, refinery and one celebrity venue marked coming soon
Careers	32 careers x 5 levels; 6,600 to 99,000 naira per shift (fan wiki, game data)
Needs	Six meters: hunger, energy, fun, social, hygiene, bladder
Transport	Five modes with prices: Trek free, Keke 200, Danfo 200, Okada 300, Cab 650 naira (verified in venue sheet)
Social	Public venue chat, DMs by username, groups, house visits, player-to-player transfers, weekly elections
Monetisation	Billboards, sea plots, stats-page slots, branded venues and in-phone app placements; real-money naira top-ups via Flutterwave
Withdrawals	Refused by design; Game Naira is non-redeemable fictional currency
Stats	Self-reported dashboard: 5.87M players, 35.2M visits, 130K online (10 Oct 2026)

Table 2.1 - Lagos Life fact sheet (all items verified against sources in Appendix A)

3. Deliverable 2 - Player Sentiment Report

How this section was built

Sentiment evidence comes from four channels: press interviews in which the creator repeats player behaviour and requests; search-indexed posts and captions on Instagram, TikTok, X and Facebook; a Nairaland discussion surface; and the fan-guide ecosystem, whose very existence within eight days is itself a retention signal. We could not open native comment threads without personal accounts, so themes below are anchored to specific platforms, dates and URLs rather than verbatim quotes. Where a claim traces only to the developer, it is labelled as such. No sentiment percentages are offered, because nothing in the evidence supports a number.

Recurring praise

Theme 1 - It is finally a game about us

The dominant note across every channel is cultural recognition. Players celebrate seeing their own city, slang, food, music and hustle economics reflected back as gameplay - amala spots, the Shrine, Quilox, NEPA, danfo, spraying money at parties, LAPO loans. Vanguard's explainer (6-7 October) frames the whole game as recognisable Nigerian experiences turned into gameplay; an Instagram reel caption from 5 October begins Lagos Life is supposed to be a game, but somehow it... - the viral format of the sentence itself signals identification rather than evaluation; and Arise TV's segment (October) is literally titled how Lagos Life is capturing young Nigerians online. For our purposes the mechanism matters more than the volume: the praise is aimed at content and voice, not graphics. Lagos Life's 3D is charming but simple; its writing is what players screenshot and share.

Theme 2 - Other real people are the product

The second recurring theme is aliveness. The landing page sells it before signup - 132k online now, 29.2 million visits, real avatars walking the map with username tags - and the game keeps those counters visible during play. The Facebook explainers (7 October) emphasise meeting and making friends inside the world; the fan guides document house visits, chatting and money transfers as core activities rather than extras; and the official accounts' reply patterns push players toward meetups and the weekly election. Multiple press pieces converge on the same judgement: the shared world, not the simulation depth, is what distinguishes Lagos Life from a traditional single-player life simulator (Vanguard, 7 October).

Theme 3 - Zero-friction access

Praise also concentrates on the delivery model: no download, no store, no storage anxiety, play within seconds of tapping a link (Technext, 7 October, notes this removed the app-store tax that killed earlier Nigerian games). The TikTok ecosystem around the game consists largely of how-to tutorials - how to add Lagos Life to your home screen on Android (4 October), how to get the game on iPhone (5 October) - showing an audience that needed hand-holding and got it from the community itself. The in-game install banner and the new Android wrapper both respond to this demand directly.

Recurring complaints and friction

- Economy imbalance and resets. The founder herself reports the economy was flooded through a loophole; some players held trillions; the fix zeroed transfer-only accounts (Techpoint, 9 October; Fosudo interview, 7 October). Every reset creates its own aggrieved group.
- Connection reliability. The fan guide's most-visited troubleshooting page is for a Reconnecting to Lagos state and login failures from Instagram in-app browsers - real friction for exactly the viral traffic the game lives on.
- Waiting-based pacing. The Play Store description frames everything as costing in-game minutes the city has a limited supply of; guides describing shift schedules and Saturday rent imply waiting is a designed scarcity, which some players clearly love and others will find slow.
- Trust and safety surroundings. TechBrief Africa (7 October) warns there is no official APK and that fake files circulate - a direct consequence of viral demand outrunning official channels; the Terms reveal device fingerprinting and enforcement machinery that implies meaningful moderation load in an 18+

social space.

- Withdrawal expectations. Players repeatedly ask whether game naira can become real money; the answer is no, and managing that expectation is an ongoing reputational task (Techpoint, 9 October).

Observed feature requests and how fast they were granted

The most instructive sentiment pattern is velocity. Players asked for more cities on day one; Abuja and Port Harcourt shipped on day six. Players wanted an app; a Play Store wrapper appeared by day eight to ten. Players wanted to feel wealthy; luxury goods for the new class were added. Players ask for withdrawals; that one is refused, and no redeem-code system exists (the fan wiki explicitly warns that sites offering Lagos Life codes are fabricating them). The lesson for us is not the specific features - it is that publicly shipping visible responses to player requests within days is itself a driver of the community's goodwill and content creation.

Sentiment cautions

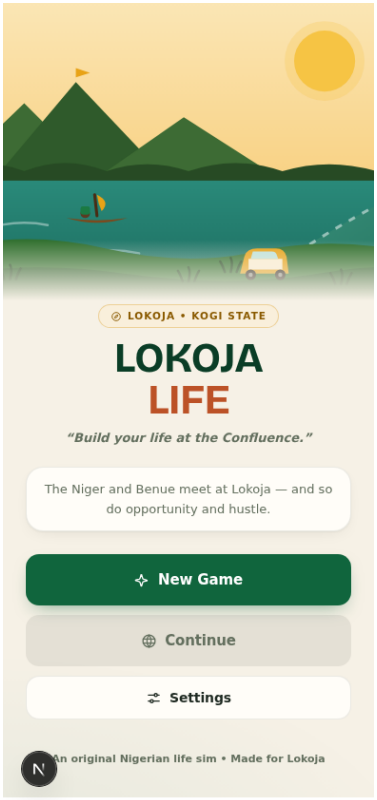
Three cautions govern how much weight to put on all of the above. First, hype-cycle distortion: TechBrief Africa and Arise both explicitly warn that week-one numbers and enthusiasm decay, and the real test is thirty-day retention, which nobody can see yet. Second, single-source economics: the 38 percent tap-through, the 46,900 dollar first-four-days revenue and every player count originate from the developer's own dashboards and statements. Third, audience skew: an 18+ gate and viral TikTok distribution mean the visible commentariat is young, urban and online-first; it does not represent the whole potential market for a Nigerian life sim, which is good news for a game like ours that can serve different strengths.

4. Deliverable 3 - Visual and UI Comparison

This chapter answers the feedback precisely. Everything below was captured first-hand: Lagos Life screens from our research session on 10 October 2026 at a 390 by 844 phone viewport, and Lokoja Life screens from a clean save on the same viewport on the same day. Judgements separate visual craft from gameplay depth - a prettier screen is not automatically a better system, and we say which is which. The pattern that emerges is consistent: Lagos Life wins on aliveness, density of meaning and moment-to-moment delight; Lokoja Life wins on coherence, engineering honesty and world ambition. Both are competent; they are polished in different directions.



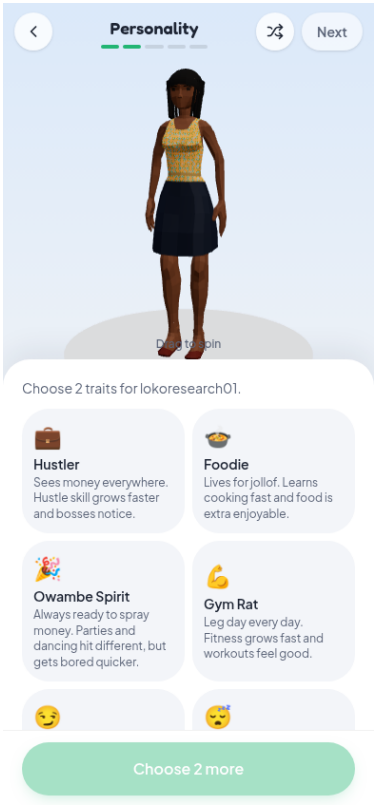
Lagos Life landing (10 Oct 2026)



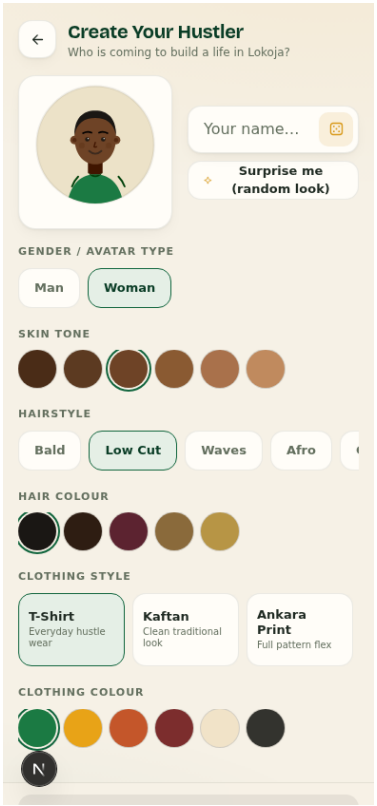
Lokoja Life main menu (10 Oct 2026)

4.1 First impression: the world is the menu

Lagos Life's landing page is the live city itself: an angled 3D map where real players' avatars wander between venues, billboards sell real ad space, and pill chips report 132k online now, 29.2 million visits, the current governor, sea plots and 400 homes. One green Sign up free button anchors the bottom. The composition makes three decisions we can name: first, the product demonstrates itself instead of describing itself - you watch people playing before you join them; second, social proof is ambient and numeric rather than testimonial; third, there is exactly one primary action on screen. Our main menu is a handsome static SVG illustration of Mount Patti and the confluence with a clean wordmark and three buttons - visually coherent, honestly labelled, and completely inert. Nothing moves, no live data exists anywhere, and the gap a viewer feels is not colour or font; it is that their first screen is alive and ours is a poster.



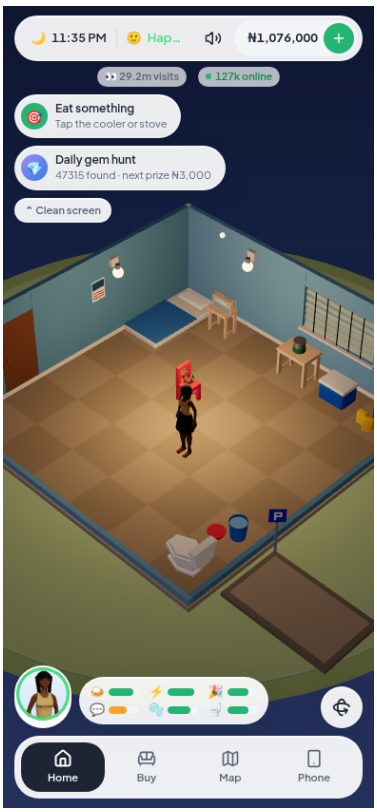
Lagos Life creation step 2 of 5 (traits)



Lokoja Life character creation

4.2 Character creation: a story versus a form

Lagos Life splits creation into five steps with progress dots, and the star of every step is a rotatable 3D character - same model, real depth, drag-to-spin. Each choice is narrated: traits carry mechanical promises (Lazy Bone: energy lasts longer, work suffers a bit), the birth lottery rolls with visible suspense and lands on a memorable identity moment (we rolled LAPO Baby with the line: self-made hits different), and the home step presents trade-offs in plain language with one locked aspiration. Our creation screen offers more granular customisation - five hairstyle groups, six hair colours, four clothing styles, six colours - but presents it as one long scrolling form around a flat 2D avatar in a circle, with no steps, no suspense and no mechanical storytelling. The result reads as tidy administration where theirs reads as the game's first chapter. Notably, our layered-SVG avatar system is genuinely original artwork; it simply renders flat, and flatness is what the eye registers.



Lagos Life home interior at night



Lokoja Life 3D world HUD (Home district)

4.3 The home screen: furnished room versus open world

After onboarding, Lagos Life seats the player inside a furnished 3D room - bed, desk, window light, waste bin - that rotates on request, with six needs as coloured mini-pills beside the avatar, a time-and-wallet header, and two task cards that each contain an action and a destination: eat something, tap the cooler or stove; daily gem hunt, 47,315 found, next prize 3,000 naira. Our equivalent moment drops the player into our genuinely full-bleed 3D Lokoja with a frosted-glass HUD - location chip, cash and level, day and time with weather, condition, joystick, sprint and camera rail - which is, by every technical measure, the more ambitious build. But at rest our camera shows sparse grass, scattered houses and two pedestrians; there are no interactive props at street level, no task card telling the player what to do next, and no evidence of any life beyond wandering NPCs. Their screen is smaller in ambition and denser in meaning; ours is bigger in ambition and quieter at first touch. The HUD craft itself is close - our glass chips are arguably more elegant than their header row - the difference is what the world beneath it is doing.



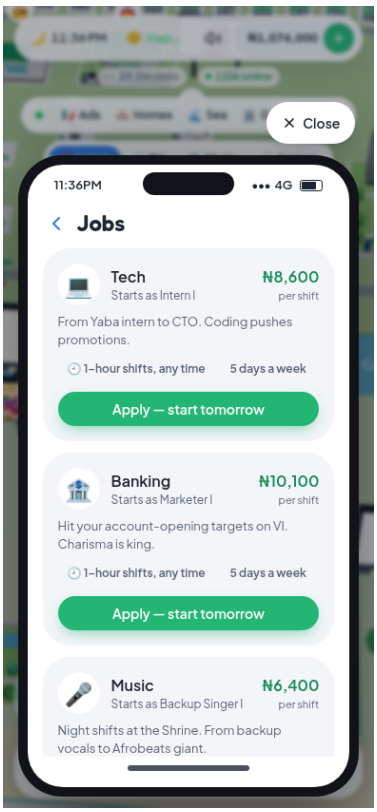
Lagos Life map: zoomed live 3D city



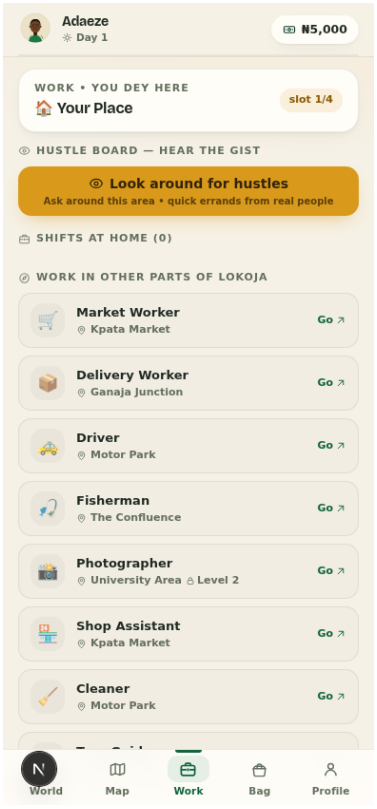
Lokoja Life map: stylised 2D atlas

4.4 The map: a place versus an atlas

Lagos Life's map is not a diagram; it is the same live 3D city zoomed out, with filter chips (ads, homes, sea, gov, walk), a city switcher to Abuja and Port Harcourt, a names toggle, and player avatars visibly moving through it. Tapping a venue opens a sheet like The Library, whose description promises a secret bookcase entrance, moody lights and a packed dancefloor, then lists ten named activities - find the secret bookcase, dance to the DJ, spray money, order the gold bottle - plus a player-shops-here row and five transport options with prices. Our map is a carefully drawn 2D atlas of Lokoja with ten markers, honest state badges and correct fares, followed by a lot of cream-coloured silence; the location sheet is clean but lists stage-gated coming soon chips where theirs lists things to actually do. Ours is the better document of our world; theirs is the better invitation into theirs.



Lagos Life Jobs app (phone)



Lokoja Life Work screen

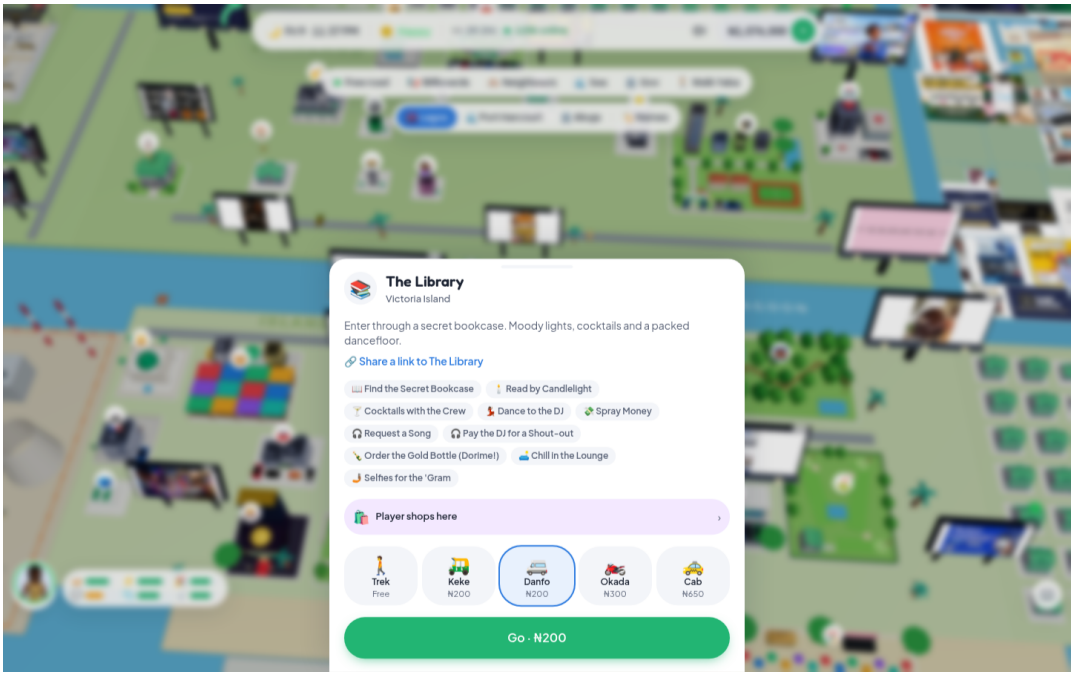
4.5 Work and jobs: careers with voice versus a noticeboard

The Lagos Life Jobs app presents career cards inside the phone: Tech, starting as Intern I at 8,600 naira per shift, from Yaba intern to CTO, one-hour shifts at any time, five days a week, with a fat green Apply - start tomorrow button. Banking cites account-opening targets on VI and calls charisma king; Music begins at backup singer with night shifts at the Shrine. Every card answers three questions at a glance - what do I earn, what is the rhythm, where does it lead - and applying confirms with a notification that names your first shift and promises a go-to-work tap when it is time. Our Work screen is a functional noticeboard: a hustle board call-to-action, shifts at this location, and a long list of jobs elsewhere with emoji-in-disc icons and Go links that correctly deep-link to the map. The underlying economics are sound and tested, but the presentation is a list of vacancies where theirs is a set of career identities, and the empty rows at our screen edges make the screen feel sparse rather than calm.

4.6 The social layer, and the hole where ours would be

Their phone grid - sixteen system apps plus paid third-party placements - and its Messages app with chats, groups and push notifications have no counterpart in Lokoja Life at all, because Stage 4 has not been built and we deliberately did not build it in this phase. We record it here as the single largest structural gap in the comparison, with one important nuance: our architecture is already prepared for it. Our opportunities are plain data that can arrive from any source including phone, our NPCs are a stable registry with homes and speech styles, and our location IDs are the same ones a chat would reference. The competitor's chat works because real humans are on the other end; ours can be honest precisely because it will be fiction with memory - NPCs who know where you have been. That is a different product promise, and chapter 6 argues it

is our strongest differentiator, but today the screen does not exist and theirs does.



Lagos Life on desktop: centred sheet over a blurred, still-live city

4.7 Responsive behaviour

On a 1440 by 900 desktop viewport, Lagos Life renders the world full-bleed and centres its sheets over a blurred, still-animating city, so the aliveness survives even in a modal. Our game locks to a max-width column on the same viewport - clean, readable and obviously mobile-first, with the 3D world full-bleed behind the HUD exactly as designed. Both approaches are legitimate; theirs spends desktop space on atmosphere, ours on focus. We note it because the viewer who compared the two products was likely looking at exactly this kind of side-by-side, where their background motion registers as polish and our white columns register as a website.

4.8 Why our UI reads older: the concrete list

Synthesising the code audit (Task 5-a, in the worklog) with the screenshots, our visual age comes from six specific, fixable causes rather than a general badness. Each has an exact owner file, which is why the roadmap can cost them realistically.

Shortcoming	Evidence	Owner files
Emoji as content art	92 emoji literals across data files; locations, jobs, foods, NPCs render emoji at text-3xl inside coloured squares; literal residue like fallback smileys in WorkScreen	src/game/data/*.ts, WorkScreen, LocationSheet, MapScreen
Static first screen	Menu is a hand-drawn SVG poster; no motion, no live data, one keyframe-rich but silent scene	MainMenu, SceneBackdrop

Shortcoming	Evidence	Owner files
Sparse mid-game screens	Map and Work screens show large empty cream areas; list rows without imagery; no live counters anywhere	MapScreen, WorkScreen, Dashboard
Flat 2D avatar in creation	Layered SVG in a circle versus a rotatable 3D character; single-scroll form without steps	CharacterCreation, Avatar
Only three animations	lko-float, lko-pop, lko-toast; instant screen swaps; no skeletons, no transitions between screens	globals.css
No live layer	Nothing on any screen communicates that the world exists right now; no ticker, no daily event, no presence	Dashboard, WorldView, data/config

Table 4.1 - Concrete visual shortcomings in Lokoja Life, with evidence

4.9 What we should keep precisely because it is already good

Honest comparison also protects strengths. Our Confluence design system - CSS-variable palette, a 40-glyph custom stroke icon set, one Btn and SheetShell kit, tokenised radii and shadows - is more disciplined than the competitor's styling, which leans on default framework components and emoji. Our 3D world is the category leap theirs does not attempt: a continuous, walkable, 640-unit Lokoja with real roads, a bridge, districts, day-night and weather, driven by one movement controller covered by 45 headless tests. Our economy is deterministic and ledgered to the naira; our save system migrates versions defensively; 136 checks pass. The right plan is not to copy their look - it is to keep our systems and raise our presentation to the standard their presentation sets.

5. Deliverable 4 - Feature Comparison

The matrix below separates what each product has actually implemented from what it has partially implemented, announced, or left unverified. Lagos Life entries were verified by direct observation in our session, its own Terms and disclaimer, its Play Store listing, its stats page, or named press reports; classifications follow the user's four-tier requirement. The purpose is calibration, not scorekeeping: a feature list means nothing without quality, but a quality gap must be measured against the right baseline.

Category	Lagos Life - observed evidence	Lokoja Life - current state	LL status
World presentation	Stylised 3D city, zoomable live map, day-night ambience; interiors are single rooms	Continuous walkable 640-unit 3D Lokoja: terrain, both rivers, confluence, Mount Patti, bridge, 10 districts, 300+ buildings, traffic and pedestrians	Implemented

Category	Lagos Life - observed evidence	Lokoja Life - current state	LL status
Player movement	Tap-to-move and room rotation; no analog walking observed	Analog joystick + keyboard, sprint, camera-relative movement, collision, terrain-safe camera; 45 movement tests	Partial (no free walking observed)
Multiplayer	Shared world, live counters, visible player avatars, house visits, transfers - observed live	None; single-player by design this stage	Implemented
Chat and social	Venue chat, DMs by username, groups, notifications - Terms + empty states observed	None; NPC registry and opportunity sources are phone-ready in data	Implemented
Phone	Full phone OS metaphor, 16+ apps, paid third-party placements	No phone; BottomNav hosts five tabs instead	Implemented
Jobs and careers	32 careers x 5 levels, phone apply flow, shift schedules - verified in Jobs app	10 jobs + 16 NPC hustles, requirements, cooldowns, crits, risk rolls; 48 economy tests	Implemented (comparable)
Needs	Six meters with decay; consequences implicit	Four needs (energy, food, mood, health) with clamps, mood-pay coupling, starving penalties; tested	Implemented (different model)
Housing	4 starter homes, Saturday rent, furniture, houses owned by real players visible	10 locations but no home interior or rent cycle yet	Implemented (deeper)
Ownership and business	8 businesses from 150,000 naira, land plots, sea plots (fan wiki; not personally verified)	Entrepreneur job exists; no business ownership system yet	Partial / unverified
Transport	Five modes with prices, inter-city flight and bus	Three modes (walk, keke, taxi) with distance fares, weather and location modifiers; 17 travel tests	Implemented (comparable)
Economy depth	Taxes, investments, betting, insurance per Terms; imbalance incident admitted	Ledger, deterministic payouts, skill caps, cooldowns on one clock; no tax or investment systems	Announced / partial
Governance	Weekly governor election with gameplay decrees - observed notification	None	Implemented
Live events	Daily server-wide gem hunt, compensation gifts, minimum-wage decree - observed	Travel events (4 types) only; no global events	Partial
Monetisation	Billboards, brand placements, paid in-phone apps, real-money top-ups via Flutterwave - Terms verified	None	Implemented
Accounts and saves	Server accounts, one shared world; soft deletion in Terms	Local save v2 with migration, debounced autosave, cloud-ready payload; 100 percent offline	Different model

Category	Lagos Life - observed evidence	Lokoja Life - current state	LL status
Multi-city	Lagos, Abuja, Port Harcourt with inter-city travel - Play Store and press verified	One deeply built city (Lokoja) with 10 districts	Implemented
Visual identity	Emoji-led content art, iOS-metaphor styling, heavy live data	Confluence token system, custom 40-glyph icon set, frosted HUD, original SVG art	Comparable, different taste
Engineering quality	Unknown; connection issues documented; solo dev shipping daily	136 passing checks, typed systems, deterministic core, migration-safe saves	Ours verified, theirs unverified
Ads platform	Self-serve billboards and stats slots with public prices	None	Implemented
Walkable exploration	Not observed; venues accessed via map and transport	Core identity: walk, sprint, settle on foot, energy cost, near-chips	Partial / not observed

Table 5.1 - Feature-by-feature comparison with evidence tier

Unverified and announced items, called out

- One billion dollar self-valuation (founder, Fosudo interview, 7 October) - contrast with the actual 10 million dollar priced round one day later; treat all founder valuations as marketing.
- 38 percent ad tap-through - one campaign, own metrics, no audit (TechBrief Africa, 6 October).
- Native iOS and Android apps by end of October - founder claim; today's Play Store entry is a wrapper.
- Airport, refinery and the celebrity venue marked coming soon on the official map - announced, not built.
- Facebook streaming, football streaming and music promotion revenue - stated by the founder to TechCabal and Techpoint; no public artefact verifies scale.

6. Deliverable 5 - Gap Analysis: the Ten Most Important Improvements

Ten candidate improvements were ranked by four criteria: player impact (how many players feel it, how soon), implementation cost against our current architecture, risk of breaking working systems, and strategic value (whether it builds a moat Lagos Life cannot cheaply copy). Cost is expressed in units of focused work on our existing stack - S is roughly one to three days, M is one to two weeks, L is three to six weeks - since our architecture's readiness changes each estimate materially. The ranking deliberately front-loads presentation and first-session work, because the evidence says that is where we are losing players, and it protects the engineered core, because that is where we are winning.

#	Improvement	Impact	Cost	Risk	Strategic value
1	First-session story pass: identity moment, guided first tasks, first-paycheck beat	Very high	M	Low	Directly attacks the five-minute drop-off the feedback represents
2	Aliveness layer: live-feel ticker, daily Lokoja event, ambient world activity	Very high	M	Low	Cheap, honest single-player analogue of their social proof
3	Phone v1: Jobs, Messages, Map and Status as one in-world shell	High	L	Medium	Unifies existing systems; NPC chat with memory is our moat
4	Content art bar: replace emoji squares with consistent illustrated or 3D props	High	M	Low	Removes the single most visible tell of unpolish
5	Venue activities: 8-12 named, cultural, mechanical activities per location	High	M	Low	Turns 10 correct locations into 10 places worth visiting
6	Menu-to-world continuity: menu shows the living world behind the wordmark	Medium	S	Low	Fixes the first-screen impression at trivial cost
7	Motion and transition pass: screen transitions, skeletons, press feedback	Medium	S	Low	Perceived-quality multiplier across every screen
8	Home interior and Saturday rent: a furnished room the player owns	High	L	Medium	Gives money a sink and homecoming a feeling; rent cycle adds cadence
9	NPC routines and memory made visible	High	M	Medium	Our differentiator; no browser competitor has NPC memory
10	Signature vistas: Mount Patti sunrise and confluence moments as composed scenes	Medium	S	Low	Identity only Lokoja can claim; screenshot bait

Table 6.1 - Top ten improvements, ranked

Why these ten, in detail

1 through 3 form the response to the actual complaint. The first-session pass converts our character form into a story with an identity beat of equivalent memorability to the birth lottery, then uses task cards with destination affordances - the pattern their Eat something card proves - to remove every silent moment from the first five minutes. The aliveness layer is the honest single-player translation of their social proof: a Lokoja news ticker driven by the one world clock, a daily server-independent event with a shared counter, and crowds that thicken with the time of day. The phone is the largest item and the most strategic, because our data layer was explicitly built phone-ready: offers are typed with source fields, NPCs are a registry with homes and speech styles, and the UI kit already contains the sheet chrome a phone app needs.

4 through 7 are the presentation multiplier. Replacing emoji-as-art with a consistent illustrated set (or instanced 3D props for street objects) removes the mixed art bar our own audit flagged as the biggest single tell. Venue activities give every pin on the map something to do - their Library sheet, with ten named activities and five transport prices, is the exact shape we should match and then exceed with location-specific mechanics like Patti hikes and riverside fishing. The menu continuity and motion passes are small, low-risk changes with outsized perceived effect, precisely because our token system and kit make them systematic rather than bespoke.

8 through 10 build the parts of the game only we can claim. A home interior with Saturday rent gives the economy a heartbeat and the player a private space; our locations already carry home as a stable ID, and the terrain and building registries can anchor an interior without touching the save schema beyond new fields. Visible NPC routines and memory - Musa at the junction remembering your last carry, Hajiya Amina paying better on market day - convert our existing silent registries into the feature nobody else in this genre has shipped in a browser. And the vista work costs almost nothing because the world already exists: it is camera choreography and a postcard moment, and it is the screenshot that answers Lagos Life on its own terms.

7. Deliverable 6 - Recommended Roadmap

Five stages, ordered by dependency and evidence, each with the specific files it touches, the evidence that motivates it, and how we will know it worked. Nothing here rewrites working systems; every stage composes existing primitives. The roadmap deliberately does not include multiplayer, real-money currency, or an ads platform - chasing those would abandon our advantages for someone else's game, and chapter 8 explains why.

Stage R1 - Raise the visual bar to premium (1-2 weeks)

Motivation: chapter 4's finding that our craft is coherent but quiet, and their screens feel alive. Work: menu-to-world continuity (render the 3D world or an animated scene behind the menu); screen transition system beyond the current three keyframes; replace emoji content art with a consistent illustrated set beginning with locations and jobs; MapScreen and WorkScreen density passes to remove empty regions; NeedsBar colours moved onto tokens. Files: MainMenu.tsx, SceneBackdrop.tsx, globals.css, ui/icons.tsx, MapScreen.tsx, WorkScreen.tsx, NeedsBar.tsx, Dashboard.tsx; new ui/illustrations set. Guardrails: no store, data or save changes; 136 checks must stay green. Success measures: side-by-side screenshots at 360, 390 and 1280 px no longer read as older in a blind comparison of any single screen; zero emoji rendered as UI art; every screen transition animated under 250 ms.

Stage R2 - First-session story pass (2-3 weeks, overlaps R1 tail)

Motivation: their five-step wizard ends in a room with a task in under five minutes; our creation is a form and our first minute is silent. Work: restructure creation into 3-4 guided steps with a named identity beat (a Lokoja welcome moment with the same memorability as the birth lottery - for example a starting hustle story

that grants an honest starting bonus and a first contact); add a first-session task rail using the task-card pattern with destination deep-links we already have; ensure the first naira is earned within three minutes on default paths. Files: CharacterCreation.tsx, new systems/onboarding.ts (pure, testable), config.ts STARTING block, store boot path, Dashboard task cards. Guardrails: startNewGame contract and save v2 schema unchanged; onboarding is pure functions over existing state. Success measures: new-save players reach first payout inside 180 seconds; D0 task completion measurable in stats; no regression in the 48 economy tests.

Stage R3 - Phone v1: one shell for Jobs, Messages, Map, Status (3-4 weeks)

Motivation: their phone is the retention engine; our architecture was built phone-ready and the audit confirms the seams. Work: a PhoneShell overlay (not a rewrite of BottomNav) hosting four apps that wrap existing screens as panels: Jobs (WorkScreen content), Messages (new NPC chat over the opportunity system - offers arrive as messages from NPC registries with source phone), Map (MapScreen), and My Status (StatusPanel); notification badges reuse the existing has-opportunities selector. Files: new components/game/phone/*, WorkScreen refactor into panels, npcs.ts (message templates), opportunities.ts (source already supports phone), store selectors. Guardrails: opportunity eligibility, cooldowns and ledger untouched; the same data must render in both the old tab layout and the phone during migration. Success measures: share of offers accepted via Messages in analytics events; session length delta; zero change in payout maths across both surfaces.

Stage R4 - World aliveness and venue activities (4-6 weeks)

Motivation: their world demonstrates itself everywhere; ours needs reasons to be in it. Work: a Lokoja ticker and daily event driven by the one world clock (no second time system); 8-12 named activities per location wired to real mechanics - eat at Food Strip via the existing foods data, carry fabric at Kpata via hustles, hike Patti with an energy-and-view reward, fish the confluence; NPC routines surfaced (schedule tables per NPC home and workplace) and a memory layer for greetings that reference past interactions. Files: world.ts (event roll on the existing clock), new data/activities.ts, LocationSheet.tsx, Life.tsx idler positions, npcs.ts routines, store interactions. Guardrails: all outcomes flow through giveReward and the ledger; activity rewards are config-tuned. Success measures: interactions per session up; venue sheets show zero coming-soon chips for launched locations; every activity outcome deterministic under the seeded RNG used by tests.

Stage R5 - Home, ownership and signature moments (6-10 weeks)

Motivation: rent Saturdays give their economy cadence; our player has money with nothing permanent to buy. Work: a furnished home interior anchored to the existing home location (room scene with interactive props: cooler, stove, bed wired to needs actions); a Saturday rent cycle as a config-driven ledger event with consequences; furniture purchases as cash sinks; then the differentiators - Mount Patti sunrise vista moment, confluence festival day, and business ownership (kiosk upgrades) built on the existing building registry positions. Files: new HomeInterior.tsx, progression or new systems/ownership.ts, config ECONOMY rent block, Life.tsx interactive props, CameraRig vista choreography. Guardrails: save v2 fields added additively with migration defaults; no existing ID changes. Success measures: rent cycle executes on the shared clock with ledger entries; furniture spend visible in stats; the Patti vista produces a screenshot we would publish.

Stage	Theme	Primary evidence answered	Exit criterion
R1	Premium visual bar	Chapter 4 screenshot gaps	Blind single-screen comparison no longer reads older
R2	First-session story	5-minute experience gap (4.1-4.3)	First payout within 3 minutes on default path
R3	Phone v1	Phone and social gap (4.6)	Offers accepted through Messages without payout drift
R4	Aliveness and activities	Live-layer gap (4.3, 4.4)	Zero coming-soon chips at launched locations
R5	Home, ownership, vistas	Housing and identity gaps (Table 5.1)	Rent cycle live; publishable Patti vista

Table 7.1 - Roadmap summary and dependency order

8. The Final Question Answered

The question: if a new player opens Lagos Life and Lokoja Life today, why might they prefer Lagos Life, and what are the five highest-impact things we should change to make them choose Lokoja Life instead? The honest answer has three layers. In the first sixty seconds, Lagos Life feels alive and ours feels quiet: their landing screen is a city full of real people with live counters, our landing screen is a poster; their creation flow is a story with suspense, ours is a form. In the first session, theirs hands the player a furnished home, a phone, a job and a named next action within about four minutes, while ours drops the player into a beautiful but under-explained world where the strongest early option is reading a noticeboard. And across days, their reason to return is other people - chat, elections, shared events, visible player homes - where ours currently has none, because the systems that would carry it are built but unexposed. None of these are engine gaps. All three are presentation, pacing and exposure gaps over an engineered core that is, by the measures we can verify, ahead of theirs.

The uncomfortable findings, stated without cushioning. First, our UI modernisation pass succeeded on its own terms - tokens, icons, consistency - and still loses the comparison, because consistency is not the axis players judge; aliveness and density of meaning are. Second, our most technically impressive strength, the walkable 3D world, is at first touch our least impressive screen: sparse at rest, without street-level interactions or a task layer, it under-delivers relative to its ambition. Third, the competitor ships daily in public with monetisation from day one; we ship in disciplined stages - right for systems, but it means every week we wait, their lead in perceived momentum compounds. Fourth, their social layer is a genuine moat we cannot and should not fake; pretending single-player notifications are friends would be worse than silence. Our answer must be a different moat: the world, the NPCs, the culture of Kogi state, and honest simulation depth.

The five highest-impact changes

1. Make the first five minutes a story: guided creation steps with one memorable identity beat, then task cards with destinations so the first naira is earned inside three minutes (Stage R2).
2. Build the aliveness layer: a Lokoja news ticker, a daily shared event with a visible counter, time-of-day crowd rhythms - the honest single-player equivalent of their social proof (Stage R4, first slice).
3. Ship Phone v1: Jobs, Messages from NPCs with memory, Map and Status in one shell over the existing opportunity system - the retention surface they proved, implemented our way (Stage R3).
4. Raise the content art bar: replace every emoji-as-art surface with consistent illustration and give the 3D world street-level interactive props, so the craft matches the engineering (Stage R1 plus R4 props).
5. Claim the identity only we can claim: Mount Patti and the confluence as composed signature moments, NPC routines and memory made visible, and a home with a Saturday rent heartbeat - Lokoja, not Lagos-lite (Stage R5).

What we deliberately will not build

Multiplayer servers, real-money currency, withdrawals and a self-serve ad platform are out of scope for the coming stages. Multiplayer is a company-scale operational burden the competitor is still learning to carry - economy floods, resets, moderation, device fingerprinting per its own Terms - and it would abandon our advantage in verified, deterministic quality. Real-money naira would import regulatory and trust obligations our fictional ledger should never touch. This is not timidity; it is choosing the game we can be best in the world at: the most alive, most honest, most deeply Nigerian single-player life sim in a browser, set in a city whose name literally means the confluence - where two rivers meet and make something stronger.

Appendix A - Source Register

All sources were accessed on 10 October 2026 from within this session unless noted. Player-facing statistics and revenue figures are self-reported by the developer unless the row says otherwise. Screenshots referenced in chapter 4 are stored under research/screenshots in the repository.

#	Source	URL	Used for
A1	Lagos Life official site	https://lagoslife.app/	Landing UI, venue list, live counters, cookie policy
A2	Official live stats	https://lagoslife.app/stats	Player/visit counters, creator attribution
A3	Terms of Use	https://lagoslife.app/terms	Accounts, Game Naira rules, ads products, moderation, 18+

#	Source	URL	Used for
A4	Game and Brand Disclaimer	https://lagoslife.app/disclaimer	Fictionalisation, brands, institutions, no endorsement
A5	Google Play listing	https://play.google.com/store/apps/details?id=com.greatcallie.lagoslife	Android wrapper, six needs, multi-city, GreatCallie
A6	Vanguard explainer	https://www.vanguardngr.com/2026/10/lagos-life-game-crosses-2-million-users-heres-how-to-play	2M players, city expansion, how-to-play (6-7 Oct)
A7	Techpoint valuation	https://techpoint.africa/news/lagos-life-10m-valuation	Funding, infra costs, revenue streams, economy admits (9 Oct)
A8	TechCabal funding note	https://techcabal.com (Lagos Life maker Vatar raises $500,000)	Five revenue streams, 4.3M players (8-9 Oct)
A9	TechBrief billboards	https://techbrief.africa/lagos-life-virtual-billboard-advertising	Ad pricing, 38 percent tap-through, risks (6 Oct)
A10	Technext history	https://technext24.com/reviews/lagos-life-5-lagos-themed-games-ai	Launch curve, Nigerian gaming history, AI-built (7 Oct)
A11	Fan wiki (independent)	https://lagoslifeguide.com/	Onboarding data, careers, rents, birth lottery, FAQ
A12	Fosudo interview	YouTube, Fisayo Fosudo channel (7 Oct 2026, via press reports)	Founder claims, valuation quote, apps plan
A13	Arise TV segment	https://www.arise.tv (How Lagos Life is capturing young Nigerians)	Independent player-count anchor, cultural framing
A14	Nairaland thread	https://www.nairaland.com (Lagos Life hype thread, 6 Oct)	Community discussion surface
A15	TikTok tutorials	https://www.tiktok.com/discover (4-5 Oct 2026)	Install behaviour, audience hand-holding
A16	Lagos Life live session	lagoslife.app via research account lokoresearch01 (10 Oct 2026)	All chapter 4 observations and screenshots
A17	Lokoja Life repository audit	/home/z/my-project (worklog Task 5-a)	Our component inventory, styling census, test counts
A18	Lokoja Life test suite	scripts/test-travel|stage3|stage35|stage36 (bun)	136 passing checks verified during this audit
A19	Lokoja Life screenshots	research/screenshots/ours/ (10 Oct 2026)	Chapter 4 comparison panels
A20	Worklog Tasks 1-6	/home/z/my-project/worklog.md	Stage 1-3.6 and UI-pass history, architecture facts

Table A.1 - Sources consulted, with role in this report